

Project Summary

In February 2025, Ashland Community and Technical College began offering an Associate in Arts program at Little Sandy Correctional Complex in Sandy Hook, Kentucky.

Prison to Profession explores whether there is a gap between the education levels of incarcerated individuals and the education typically required for high-wage, high-demand jobs in Kentucky.

By identifying these gaps, the college can better demonstrate need for the program—information that may support program planning, accreditation processes, grant applications, and outreach to potential students.

Key Findings

Analysis of U.S. Census microdata and Kentucky labor market projections revealed the following:

- Incarcerated individuals in Kentucky are more likely to have completed some college or less, and are significantly less likely to hold a college degree compared to the general population.
- They are more likely than non-incarcerated Kentuckians to be working in jobs projected to grow by 5% or more (“high-demand”), but less likely to be in jobs paying \$50,000 or more (“high-wage”)—indicating that many incarcerated individuals work in low-paying but in-demand roles.
- A heatmap of jobs by required education level showed no associate degree-level jobs classified as both high-demand and high-wage. However:
 - Postsecondary nondegree awards (such as certificates or diplomas) accounted for 81 occupations that were both high-demand and high-wage.
 - If incarcerated students transfer to a 4-year institution of higher education after completing an associate degree, they could become eligible for over 600 occupations that fall into both high-wage and high-demand categories—more than any other education level analyzed.

These findings highlight the importance of not only offering certificate, diploma, and associate degree programs to incarcerated individuals, but also building pathways for students to continue their education after release.

Limitations and Data Issues

- The dataset does not include a direct “incarcerated” flag. Incarceration status had to be estimated using variables such as group quarters type, age, and income. This approach may have excluded some individuals or introduced classification errors.
- Although the Census dataset is large, limiting the analysis to Kentucky left a sample of 504 likely incarcerated individuals, which restricts regional or subgroup analysis.
- Additionally, the personal and housing datasets from the Census had to be joined by household identifier. Because one household can include multiple people, and the housing data only includes one record per household, this join reduced the total number of people retained in the merged dataset.

Despite these limitations, the analysis provides meaningful insight into the mismatch between educational preparation and economic opportunity for incarcerated Kentuckians.